Chapter 8.

DEALING WITH CHINA

Appreciating the Importance of Realism

There are few debates on the merits of realpolitik versus ideology that would match the conversations in India about China. Not surprisingly, it can also become one of nationalism versus internationalism, however misplaced the latter may be in this case. This starts from our early years of independence, meanders through an era of conflict, witnesses the subsequent normalization, and finally arrives at the choice between a ‘Chindia’ outlook and an ‘India First’ one. The impact of the border events in 2020 have recently revived this argument, contributing to a growing awareness of the complexity of the challenge before India. As a result, facets like trade, investment, technology and even contacts have begun to be viewed from an integrated perspective. The current state of the relationship is clearly unnatural; what its future holds seems ripe for debate.

In essence, the competing perspectives derive from the differing viewpoints set out in 1950 by PM Jawaharlal Nehru and his deputy, Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel. The latter was as hard-nosed as they come and least susceptible to protestations from neighbours that diverged from ground reality. In his estimation, India had done everything to allay China’s apprehensions, but that country regarded us with suspicion and scepticism, perhaps mixed with a little hostility. Patel cautioned that for the first time after centuries, India’s defence had to concentrate on two fronts simultaneously. And his view of China was that it had definite ambitions and aims that shaped its thinking about India in a less-than-friendly way.

In contrast, Nehru felt that Patel was overly suspicious and stated in a note to him on 18 November 1950 that it was inconceivable that China would ‘undertake a wild adventure across the Himalayas’. Guided by a positive predisposition towards a leftist regime, he also felt that it is exceedingly unlikely that India may have to face any real military invasion